ITIS 4390 · Interaction Design

Yale School of Art

Website Redesign

From chaos to clarity — a semester-long UX journey

GROUP 4

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Yale School of Art Website

The existing site (art.yale.edu) is one of the most notoriously chaotic university websites. Users struggle with basic tasks — and it fails across every device.

Who is affected? Prospective students, artists, and faculty

Our redesign delivers a clean, accessible, and responsive experience that lets users apply, browse events, and find information — without the chaos.

Broken Mobile Nav

Hamburger menu buttons too small to tap; no fully usable layout on phones

Visual Chaos

Cluttered layout, zero whitespace, unreadable text and no contrast

Poor Accessibility

No focus states, fails multiple WCAG AA standarts, no dark mode

Poor Feedback

No loading states, application form validation is poorly designed with a pop-up

THE PROBLEM

Yale School of Art
1156 Chapel Street, POB 208339
New Haven, Connecticut 06520-8339
Home
About the School
Apply to the School
Exhibitions
Publications
News
Public Events
Pause animations
This website exists as an ongoing collaborative experiment in digital publishing and information sharing. Because this website functions as a wiki, all members of the School of Art community—graduate students, faculty, staff, and alums—have the ability to add new content and pages, and to edit most of the site's existing content.
Content is the property of its various authors. When you contribute to this site, you agree to abide by Yale University academic and network use policy, and to act as a responsible member of our community.
Visitor: Log in
Edit this page
Page history
YALE SCHOOL OF ART
The School of Art is one of Yale's Graduate & Professional Schools conferring MFA degrees in Graphic Design, Painting/Printmaking, Photography, and Sculpture; and offers undergraduate-level art courses to Yale College students. Our website exists as an ongoing collaborative experiment in digital publishing and information sharing. It functions as a wiki—all members of the School of Art community have the ability to add new, and edit most existing content.
Editor details
QUICK LINKS
ON THIS PAGE
HAPPENING AT SOA
COMMUNITY BULLETIN BOARD
CALENDARS & NEWSLETTERS
HAPPENING AT SOA
Spring 2026 exhibitions + schedule here >
Spring 2026 Visiting Artist Lectures here > [in progress]

Home
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CLOSE
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RESEARCH & DESIGN PROCESS

10
Heuristic Evaluation
Nielsen heuristics mapped

5
Paper Sketch Testing
users, think-aloud

4
Wireframe Testing
classmate testers

3
Prototype Testing
target-user sessions

Top 3 Findings That Changed Our Design

01

Navigation Overload

Users asked for a simpler nav with fewer top-level items. We reorganized the menu into clear categories and reduced cognitive load.

02

Mobile Elements Too Small

Testers with average-sized hands struggled to tap UI elements. We enlarged all touch targets and simplified the mobile layout.

03

Dark Mode Toggle Hard to Find

Users spent 8–10 seconds searching for the color mode switch. We moved it to the top-right of every page with a clear label.

DESIGN EVOLUTION

1 Heuristic Evaluation

- Identified 7 usability issues
- Mapped to Nielsen's 10 heuristics
- Picked most relevant issues

2 Paper Sketches

- 8 key screens drawn
- Mobile + desktop versions
- 5 design goals defined

3 Wireframes (Figma)

- 10 screens (5 mobile+5 desktop)
- Grayscale structure only
- Tested with 4 classmates

4 Hi-Fi Prototype

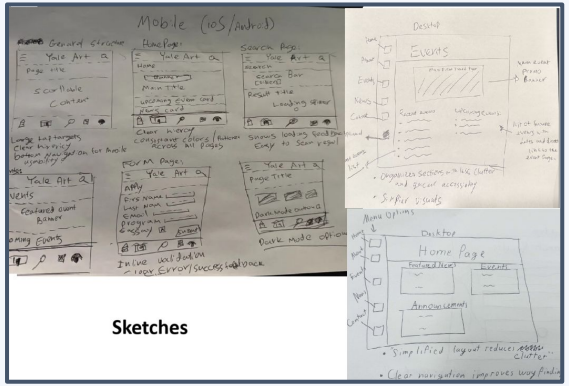
- Full color + interactions
- Dark mode, search, forms
- Tested with 3 real users

5 Live Website

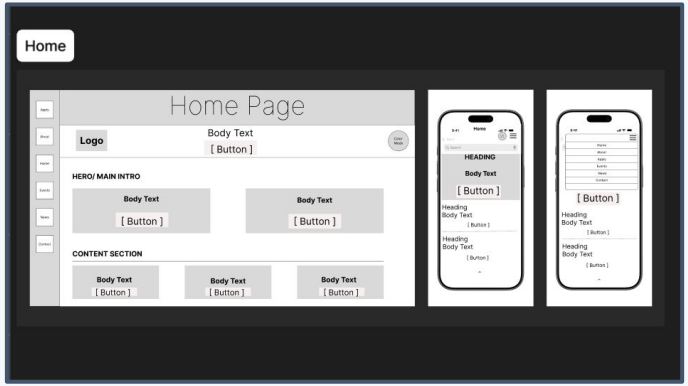
- HTML + CSS + JavaScript
- Deployed to GitHub Pages
- Responsive & accessible

DESIGN EVOLUTION

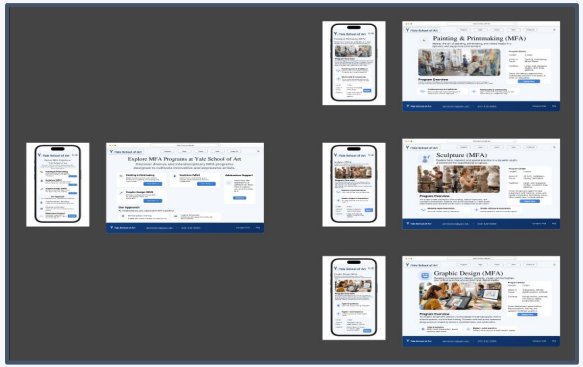
Paper Sketches



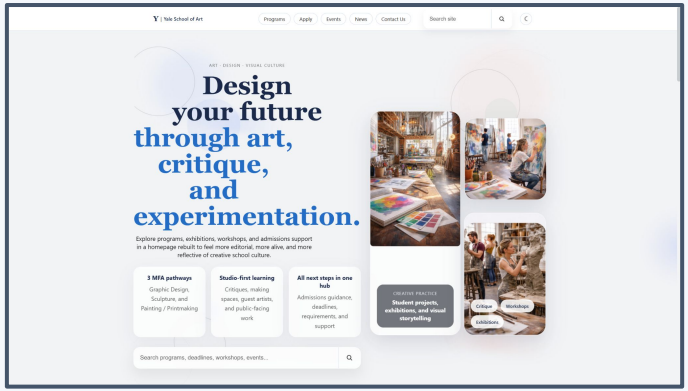
Wireframes (Figma)



Hi-Fi Prototype



Live Website



LIVE DEMO

Yale School of Art Redesign

giancarlopretell.github.io/Interaction-Design-Capstone

Demo Flow

- User opens site → sees clean, responsive home page
- Toggles dark mode → entire UI switches instantly
- Searches for 'Sculpture' → real-time suggestions appear
- Navigates to Apply → fills out application form
- Receives inline validation feedback → submits

🔍 Real-Time Search

📱 Mobile Responsive

🌙 Dark Mode Toggle

✅ Form Validation

⏳ Loading States

✨ Micro-animations

RESULTS & USER FEEDBACK

What Worked Well

- All 3 prototype testers completed every task successfully
- Application flow completed in under 30 seconds on average
- Dark mode toggle found quickly after moving to top-right
- Search + autocomplete described as 'intuitive' by users
- Mobile hamburger menu opened and closed reliably

What Users Said

"The layout is easy to understand and very organized."

— Usability Tester, Wireframe Round

"The application page was very simple to use."

— Peer Testing Participant

"Dark mode is easy to find now — I like how it remembers my setting."

— Prototype Tester P2

REFLECTION & NEXT STEPS

Challenges We Faced

Wireframe Clarity

Early wireframes lacked signifiers. We learned labels and affordances are critical even in grayscale.

Usability Studies

Our first tests found 'no issues.' We rethought our task design to surface real pain points.

Prototype Fidelity

Moving from medium to high fidelity required adding variables, auto-layout, and a proper design system.

What We'd Improve Next

- Write a functional backend for submitted forms
- Connect to real Yale API data for live events + news
- Add analytics to track drop-off in the application funnel
- Validate accessibility across real user assistive scenarios
- Localize the interface for international applicants

Key Lesson: Real user feedback at every stage was the difference between a design that looks good and one that actually works.

Thank You

Group 4 · ITIS 4390

Jonny Pretell · Kirill Zakharov · Sam Suther · Ben Oz

Live Site: giancarlopretell.github.io/Interaction-Design-Capstone

GitHub: github.com/GiancarloPretell/Interaction-Design-Capstone

4
Rounds of User Testing

15+
Testers Across Semester

6
Assignments Building to Final

100%
Task Success Rate (Final Test)